



HIGHER HEALTH

2024

POLICY ON CERTIFICATION



Policy on Certification

Approved by	Higher Health Board
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Signature	
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Glossary

“Achievement” mean the recognition granted to a learner when all required learning outcomes have been successfully demonstrated.

“Appeal” means the formal petitioning by an individual against the decision made by Higher Health, after the verification process regarding the assessment, standards and quality assurance processes, not to award a qualification.

“Assessment” means the process used to identify, gather and interpret information against the required competencies in a qualification, part-qualification or skills programme in order to make a judgement about a learner’s achievement.

“Certificate” means a document indicating formal recognition by the QCTO of an occupational qualification, part qualification, (including legacy trades) or skills programme awarded to a successful learner.

“Credits” means the amount of learning contained in a qualification or part-qualification whereby one credit is equal to ten (10) notional learning hours.

“Curriculum” for the purposes of this Policy means requirements for learner achievement of a qualification or part-qualification in terms of knowledge, skills, and where relevant, work experience.

“e-Assessment” means any type of assessment that involves an electronic component and incorporates one or more of e-testing, e-portfolios and e-marking.

“e-learning” means a mode of teaching and learning that makes use of technology-mediated features.

“Final Integrated Supervised Assessment (FISA)” means a supervised final assessment for which assessment processes, tools, and results are recorded towards the achievement of a skills programme, conducted under examination conditions. These final assessments are offered online with strict proctoring conditions.

“Internal summative assessment” means a final formal summative assessment conducted at the end of each module by Higher Health, to evaluate learning achievements relating to particular components of skills programmes. These results are formally recorded and results are formally recorded and result in the issuing of the Statement of Results for entrance to the FISA

“Learner” is an inclusive term referring to anyone learning, including pupils, students, apprentices, interns, learners in learnerships, people doing training, and people learning non-formally and informally as well as people enrolled for particular qualifications or part-qualifications, and people learning in contact, distance, and self-study contexts at all levels in the system.

“Monitoring” means a continuous process of review of quality that can be conducted internally and/or externally to recommend quality improvements.

“National Qualifications Framework (NQF)” is a comprehensive system approved by the Minister of Higher Education and Training for the classification, registration, publication and articulation of quality assured national qualifications.

“National Learners’ Records Database (NLRD)” means the electronic management information system of the NQF under the authority of SAQA, which contains records of qualifications, part qualifications, learner achievements, recognised professional bodies, professional designations and associated information such as registrations and accreditations.

“NQF Act” means the South African National Qualifications Framework (NQF) Act No. 67 of 2008.

“NQF Level” means one of the series of levels of learning achievement arranged in ascending order from one to ten according to which the NQF is organised and to which qualification types are pegged.

“Occupational Qualifications Sub-Framework (OQSF)” means the sub-framework of qualifications developed and managed by the Quality Council for Trades and Occupations (QCTO).

“Quality Assurance” means the process of ensuring that specified standards or requirements for teaching learning, education administration, assessment and the recording of achievements have been met.

“Quality Council for Trades and Occupations (QCTO)” means the Quality Council for Trades and Occupations established in terms of the NQF Act No. 67 of 2008, as amended, which is mandated to achieve the objectives of the NQF and to develop and manage the OQSF.

“Quality Partner” means a body approved by the QCTO to develop assessment instruments, manage and coordinate the FISA assessments of specified NQF-registered occupational qualifications and part-qualifications.

“Revocation” means the withdrawal of a decision to issue a Skills programme Certificate to a learner and to cancel and recall the Certificate, to render such certificate to have no legal status or effect.

“Skills Development Provider (SDP)” means a provider of occupational learning accredited by the QCTO to offer occupational qualifications in terms of the Skills Development Act, as amended.

“Sector Education and Training Authority (SETA)” means a body established in terms of the Skills Development Act 1998, (Act No. 97 of 1998), as amended, to develop and implement sector skills plans and promote learning programmes; including workplace learning.

“Skills programme” means a programme that is occupationally based and when completed will constitute/contribute a credit towards a qualification registered on the NQF, according to Chapter 5 of the SDA.

“Statement of Results” means a document issued by an accredited skills development provider for theoretical, practical and workplace skills modules completed and successfully assessed.

“Verification” means establishing the authenticity of a certificate issued by the QCTO of a skills programme achieved by a successful learner.

1. Background

Higher Health is a non-profit organisation focused on the health and wellness of the youth in the post-school education and training (PSET) sector. Higher Health's model of delivering health and wellness services is to empower PSET learners to take charge of their health and wellness, through education and knowledge. Higher Health's programmes are intense, and were delivered in-person. It soon became apparent that more learners could be reached if the programmes were offered online, via e-learning. Learners also wanted recognition for attending the sessions. Higher Health therefore developed its e-learning Civic and Soft Skills Programme, which the QCTO accredited as a NQF Level 5 Skills Programme. As Higher Health worked with the content for this Skills Programme, it became apparent that all the modules were inter-connected, and that good citizenship underpinned all of the learning. Hence, the module on civic education was included as the first module, and the inter-connected nature of the modules was highlighted in the curriculum design.

The QCTO is responsible for the development, maintenance and quality assurance of qualifications on the OQSF. This includes occupational qualifications, part qualifications, skills programmes, historically registered occupational qualifications and trades listed on the NQF. The standards for any qualification are prescribed in the qualification, curriculum and assessment specification documents for the particular qualification, part qualification or skills programme.

In terms of the Skills Development Act, 1998, (Act No 97 of 1998) the QCTO has the responsibility of issuing valid certificates and for the quality assurance of occupational qualifications, part qualifications and skills programmes, which are verifiable.

In July 2023, Higher Health, the QCTO and HW SETA signed a tripartite agreement, giving Higher Health the responsibility of issuing electronic certificates to learners who have successfully completed the FISA assessments for the Civic and Soft Skills Programme. HWSETA and the QCTO will continue to monitor Higher Health's processes periodically, to ensure compliance to its and the QCTO's policies.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to describe Higher Health's approach to certification of its Civic and Soft Skills Programme.

3. Legislative and Regulatory Framework

This policy must be read in conjunction with

- i. Skills Development Act, 1998, (Act no 97 of 1998), as amended;
- ii. National Qualifications Framework (NQF) Act, 2008 (Act No. 67 of 2008), as amended;
- iii. OQSF policy 2021; and
- iv. Higher Health's Assessment Policy

4. Scope and Application

- a. This policy applies to Higher Health's skills programmes that are accredited as such by the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations (QCTO).
- b. This policy highlights Higher Health's processes in issuing certificates to learners, and its responsibility to recommend valid and reliable data to the QCTO with regard to the certification of learner achievements for Higher Health's Civic and Soft Skills programme.
- c. Higher Health is empowered to issue QCTO-approved Skills Programme Certificates for its QCTO-accredited Civic and Soft Skills Programme.
- d. A learner will be issued with a certificate if they are found to be competent in the Final Integrated Supervised Assessment (FISA) assessment.

5. Policy Objectives

- a. The objective of this policy is to make explicit the standards adopted for the certification of the Civic and Soft skills programmes, registered by the QCTO.
- b. Higher Health has established its certification standards through rigorous quality assurance processes which include:
 - i. Higher Health's Civic and Soft Skills Programme is registered with the QCTO;
 - ii. Higher Health is established as a non-profit organisation, and its processes are quality assured;
 - iii. Higher Health ensures the FISA assessment is conducted according to QCTO approved standards; and
 - iv. Certification occurs no later than 21 working days after successful completion of the FISA assessment.
- c. Higher Health's certification system ensures:
 - i. that the learner records supporting the issue of certification are in the appropriate format and comply with policies and directives; and
 - ii. that a credible learner management information system supports the process, and that all learner achievements are provided to the QCTO for upload to the QCTO's learner records information system, and the NLRD, when required.

- d. Higher Health will ensure that strict security measures are in place to protect the integrity of the certificates.

6. Certification of learners

- a. The certification process commences when a learner enrolls for the Civic and Soft skills programme. Higher Health must submit learner enrolments data to the QCTO in the QCTO approved format.
- b. To achieve the Civic and Soft skills programme a learner must successfully complete all the modules, which is confirmed through the certificates of completion issued per module, and successfully completes the Final Integrated Supervised Assessment (FISA) assessment.
- c. Higher Health may issue the QCTO-approved NQF Level 5 Skills certificate if all the conditions in b above have been met.
- d. HW SETA is responsible for the quality assurance of assessment results, after which the results are approved by the QCTO.
- e. Higher Health will issue electronic certificates to the qualifying learners, and maintain all learner records on its digital platform and in the cloud.
- f. Higher Health has developed an integrated system that issues certificates as soon as a learner has satisfied all the conditions for certification, and all quality assurance processes have been completed.
- g. The integrated platform maintains an updated database of all certificates issued and an audit trail on transactions executed by users on the system.
- h. Access control to the system is strict, with access limited to a few well-trained employees.
- i. Data is regularly and routinely backed up to the cloud, and to physical backups.
- j. Higher Health is able to verify learner records on request.
- k. Higher Health has an agreement with the QCTO to issue certificates. All electronic certificates are issued free of charge.
- l. Higher Health will not withhold a certificate from a learner for any reason, if the learner has met all the conditions stipulated in 6b above.
- m. In accordance with the rules of administrative justice, a learner must be informed of the reasons for not issuing a certificate and have the right to appeal the decision, in accordance with Higher Health's Appeal policy.
- n. Higher Health does not have a RPL Policy for this Skills Programme, as any learner with a NQF Level 1 qualification, or Grade 9 is eligible to complete the programme.
- o. Higher Health may revoke a Skills Programme certificate if it has established that the certificate was issued under irregular circumstances or where a person has not met the qualification requirements for the award of the certificate.

7. Ensuring security in the certification process

- a. A credible certification environment requires quality and security to be constantly foregrounded.
- b. The principles for ensuring security include:

- i. users with controlled access to the system;
 - ii. all activities on the system log an audit trail;
 - iii. accountable officers such as System Administrators maintain and manage user access to the system;
 - iv. the issuing of certificates takes place in a secure environment;
 - v. a record of all certificates issued is maintained;
 - vi. credible certification forms are used, which have security features that are regularly enhanced; and
 - vii. backup and storage of data is maintained.
- c. Higher Health must ensure that the electronic certificates that it issues has in-built security features, and that anyone can verify the authenticity of the certificate at any time.
 - d. Each certificate has a unique number that is recorded against the learner to whom it was issued.
 - e. Higher Health is obliged to report any acts of fraud or misrepresentation, to the QCTO.
 - f. Higher Health and the QCTO reserve the right to revoke and withdraw the skills certificate if any evidence comes to the light that confirms that the issuing of the certificate was compromised.

8. Complaints and Appeals

- a. Higher Health will investigate complaints about misrepresented and fraudulent certificates and the non-issuing of certificates.
- b. Any learner may appeal a decision of Higher Health, by following the procedures outlined in its Appeals Policy.

9. Quality assurance and monitoring of policy implementation

- a. Higher Health will monitor implementation of this Policy in terms of its internal quality assurance processes.
- b. The QCTO will monitor the certification process in terms of this policy and the SLA signed with Higher Health.